

Saga of Bishop Paul

Bishops' Sagas

Norse Sagas

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THE LIFE OF BISHOP PAUL

1

1. 1. PAUL was the son of that most noble man John, the son of Loft, the son of Sæ-mund the historian. John's mother was Thora, daughter of king Magnus Barefoot; and Paul's mother was Rag-neid, daughter of Thor-hall, and sister of Saint Thor-lac the bishop. Paul was brought up in Ord with John his father, and he himself, and others also, ever held him [Paul] in greater esteem the elder he grew.

2

2. Paul was a goodly man to look on, fair-eyed and steady-eyed, curly-haired and fair-haired, well-limbed and small-footed, bright-coloured and fair-skinned, a man of middle stature, and of all men most courtly of carriage. He was quick and well learned when he was young, and skilful at everything he did, both writing and other things.

3

3. He married young, taking to wife Herdis Cetil's daughter, a fair woman, and of good skill in all that should adorn a lady.

4

4. But when they had been a winter together Paul went abroad, and became the man of Harold, earl in the Orkneys, who held him in great esteem. And afterwards he went south to England, and was there at school, and got great learning there, so that there was scarce any example of any man having got so deep and so much knowledge in the like time. And so when he came back to Iceland, he surpassed all other men in his courtliness and his learning, and in making of [Latin] verse, and in book-lore. He was also so great a singer and musician that his song and voice excelled those of all other men that were living in his day.

5

5. At this time he went back again to stay at Ord, and there he was ever in great favour, as was his due. But a little later Paul set up

housekeeping at Scard, but at first there was but little of all that was needed, but the wise husbandry of both husband and wife, and the good-will and help of their friends, stood them in such good stead that within a short time they had plenty of everything. Yet they met with very great losses of stock; but they took it all well and bravely, and indeed it was soon as if there had been none, for their stock increased as fast as the flood-tide coming up the shore.

6

6. Paul was trusty and of few words, and affable to all his friends and all good men, but he was strict with all wicked men, thieves and evil men, a great controller over everything in his district, and prompt to help in all that needed his presence.

7

7. Paul was a priest-hood's man *or* gode, and he upheld his moot-men in all righteous cases, so that they always got the better therein.

8

8. Paul had four children, that grew up out of childhood, by Herdis his wife, two sons and two daughters; his sons were named Loft and Cetil, and his daughters Halla and Thora. They were all goodly to look on, and grew up of good parts.

9

9. Bishop Thor-lac, Paul's mother's brother, held him in great esteem, and loved him much, and often asked him to his house. But though some other chiefs were adverse *or* refractory to bishop Thor-lac, Paul was the more trusty and fully faithful to him the more others forsook him. And when bishop Thor-lac died Paul showed his loving friendliness to him more than all his noble friends.

10

2. 1. NEXT summer after the death of Saint Thor-lac the bishop, Paul was chosen bishop, but there was a very long debate over the matter; but at last it came to this, that the matter should be put to bishop Brand, chiefly by the counsel of Hall Gizor's son, and he chose Paul to go out [and be hallowed bishop]. But he [Paul] did not soon consent to

undertake the charge, and one after another went to ask him, bishop Brand and also his brothers, and others of his dearest friends, but he refused, and so went home from the Moot.

11

2. Then he went to the church-day [Dedication-day] at Ord on Seliamen's-mass [July 8, 1194] with great concern of mind. But when all had now ceased from asking him, and he saw when he thought over what was to be done that there was none left to contend with him, unless he wished to withstand God's will, — and this he surely did not wish to do, — at this moment the Holy Ghost cast it into his mind to put himself under this burden for the sake of others' needs, and with that he boldly undertook the charge which his mind had so long set him against doing.

12

3. And a little after this he went to Seal-holt, and John, his father, and his brothers with him, and at once took over all the stewardship of the bishopstead there. And straightway he asked Gizor Hall's son to abide there, for he had been there in the days of Saint Thor-lac the bishop, and was the greatest ornament to the see and the greatest furtherance to the estate thereof of all them that were there. Paul let all the managership in Seal-holt go on in the same way as it had done before, but he set priest Thor-kel Hall's son to take care of the church, and he was his first chaplain when he came out [to Iceland], but he afterwards became canon of Wer [Thickby].

13

4. Herdis took care of the homestead at Scard, and of all their children, and of all that belonged to them, in goodly and seemly wise as long as he was abroad, and it was said by all, that no children were so well brought up as their children in the whole hundred: and all this kept its shape as long as she was alive, for she was of all women the most scrupulous both for herself and others, as was often proved.

14

3. 1. PAUL went abroad the same summer that he was chosen bishop, and he was at that time in deacon's orders. He had a fair voyage till he came to Norway, and then he went to the Chipping or market-town at Niths-oyce [Nidaros], and was there through the winter until Yule passed... and of those he met there that man thought he did best who did most to pay him honour and respect, and this the rather the nobler the man was [who entertained him], and in this they did rightly.

15

2. Archbishop Eiric was in Denmark when Paul came out to be consecrated, and he was staying there with archbishop Absalom, but king Swerre-Magnus was east in Wick, whence he went to the Uplands. But after Yule Paul and his following went from the north out of the Chipping or market-town to see the king, and with him there came many of the king's men. And the king received him as well as if he had been his son or brother, and gave him as much rank and honour as he himself or his friends could ever have wished for, and the reason of this was both because the king saw better into men than other men could, and because he had better means to do as he wished, and he put forth all that was of the best to do most honour to both of them.

16

3. Bishop Thore ordained Paul priest in Hammer-chipping. It was in the Ember-days in Lent one night after Matthias-mass [Feb. 26], and afterward he went back to the king the same night, and he abode with him till he went to Denmark; and the king provided everything that he seemed to have need of for his journey. Moreover the king got all the bishops that were in the country to give him a letter with their seals. Then he went to Denmark about Lent, and came to Lund on the first day of Pasch [Easter] to see the archbishop, and, as soon as he was come, Absalom asked him to stay with him, with the greatest honour, and waited for him at the high mass when he knew that he was about to come.'

17

4. He was there with the archbishops through Easter-week, and was held in the greatest honour by them both; and counsel was taken forthwith for his consecration, for they soon got proof of what a paragon he was, both for learning and wisdom and accomplishments. And he waited for his consecration in the monastery that is called Herads-wade, but he was hallowed earlier than the time they had fixed when they parted, and the chief cause of this was that king Cnut Waldemar's son sent word that they should further his journey, as it would suit him best and those whom he was to be bishop over. And this went of a piece with his other luck, that such a noble person should honour him so greatly though he had not seen him, as to give the very counsel as he himself would have wished should be given.

18

5. Archbishop Absalom hallowed Paul bishop on the day of bishop John [April 23], eight nights before Philip and James' mass, by the counsel of archbishop Eiric, who had not then himself the sight needful to hallow him. The bishops that were at Paul's consecration were archbishop Eiric, and Peter bishop of Roes-keld. Bishop Paul gave a gold ring to archbishop Absalom, and another to bishop Eiric, and to all the others that took part at his consecration and advancement to the dignity of bishop some treasure or other. Celestine was pope when bishop Paul was consecrated. Bishop Paul was forty years old when he was consecrated bishop.

19

6. Afterwards he went to Norway, and met king Swerre, east in Wick, and went with him to Beorg-win [Bergen], and was with him until he went to Iceland the same summer, and the king honoured him ever the more in all ways, the longer he was with him and the better he knew him. All men held him in great esteem, as was to be looked for, and his kinsmen were all the most noble men in the whole country.

20

4. 1. BISHOP Paul went out to Iceland the same summer that he had been hallowed bishop, and came to Ey-frith, and there he gave a costly

feast to bishop Brand and other of his friends whom he could get there, with wine to drink, and ale, and all the other meat and drink, of the best that could be. And it was then shown forthwith at the first, as was often proved afterwards, that he was ever best pleased when he was cheering his friends as many as he could gather and his kinsfolk in worshipful entertainment with love and magnificence.

21

2. He brought home with him two glass-windows to give to the church at Seal-holt, to his ghostly spouse; and so he showed at once, which afterwards appeared still more, what was in his mind, how much he wished to adorn the church to which he was consecrated more than it ever was before, though even before it was the finest and most precious of all that were in Iceland.

22

3. This was the first honour that bishop Paul paid his see and his church, which no bishop as yet had ever done, to wit, he sung no mass before he came to his see in Seal-holt, but in all lands it is esteemed that it is as good for a man to hear a new-made priest's first mass as it is to hear an every-day bishop's mass; but how much better must this have been seeing it was the first mass of a priest and a bishop at once. And many men gathered to Seal-holt at those glad tidings to hear bishop Paul's first mass. There were many noble men that stood and heard him, John Loftsson his father, Sæ-mund and Orm his brethren, and Gizor Hall's son, and there w'as a great gathering there then. The bishop spoke a long and fair discourse, and he promised at once, what was a most welcome thing to most men, that he would ordain all the ordinances which bishop Thor-lac had ordained.

23

4. This also was manifest at once, when he began to go progresses through his diocese, how blithe and cheerful he was to all under him, and how easily he was satisfied with regard to all that was his due, both the hospitality or other things which were due to his position. And thereby he became so beloved by the whole commonalty, that well-

nigh every man held him most dear, both they that were in his diocese and no less they that were of the other diocese. It was also easy to see how rich a man he \ould become, by reason of his prudence and good management in every thing and way.

24

5. Bishop Paul had been one winter in Seal-holt before Herdis, his wife, came thither to take over the management of all within doors, and she was such a prop and stay there, both as regards the bishopstead and himself, as no other among men was, as long as he was [bishop] in the see. So great was her skill in business that before she had been more than a few winters there there was plenty of everything that was needed, and there was no need to go a-begging for anything, though there were one' hundred persons on the estate, and [of these] about seventy or eighty servants.

25

5. 1. BISHOP Paul soon saw this when he came to the see of Seal-holt, that it would be needful for him to keep up and strengthen and finish a certain thing which the holy bishop Thor-lac had shown to be his will, and towards which he had begun to buy. And this was to provide for the church-bells which Thor-lac had bought for the bishopstead in Seal-holt, and which were the best in all Iceland. He had also got out from abroad with the bells four beams twenty ells long by measure.

26

2. For this end bishop Paul then got him the man who was the best carpenter in all Iceland, whose name was Amund Arne's son, and he had a bell-house or steeple made so beautifully wrought, both in its material and in its workmanship, that it carried it over all other wooden buildings in Iceland, no less than the church itself had done before. He had a church made in the upper floor of the steeple, and a staircase to go up thereto, and he hallowed this church to Saint Thor-lac the bishop on the tenth day of Yule, and furnished the church fairly in every way, putting into it everything that was needed therefore. He let priest Atle the scribe [illuminator] paint all the roof inside the

steeple and the gable end, and hang it all below with three hangings well and fairly, and over each of the tombs of them that were buried in the steeple he let write who they were that rested there. He laid out no less money in building this steeple, as far as he could bethink himself, than 400 pieces of silver or somewhat more. He bought the bells that were in the steeple, and were the greatest treasures of their size, from a Northern man whose name was Col. He bought moreover other bells for the steeple, two of them being those of the same tone, that are above the church, and he adorned in every way that he could devise, both the church and the steeple, with every kind of furniture, tablets and crosses, and books, and images, and lamps, and glass-windows, and all kinds of bishops' vestments. He also had a noble stone coffin cunningly hewn, wherein he was laid after his death, and he had a *crypt* made in worshipful fashion in the steeple, for those men whom he thought most closely bound to him.

27

6. 1. IN the third year of bishop Paul's bishopric, his father, John Loftsson, died on All-hallow-day [Nov. 1, 1197], the man who was then the noblest chief in all Iceland. He felt it to be a great blow to him — the loss of the man who was most able to raise and strengthen his dignity, and was the most bound of all men so to do.

28

2. But Almighty God, who ever let his happiness and good fortune wax day after day and never grow less, took such care of his renown that no man before in Iceland hath ever received equal honour and dignity from his kinsmen as he got there from his near kinsman bishop Thorlac the Saint, because it was in his days that his glory and saintliness were shown forth, first in the north-country and afterwards over all Iceland and all other lands that were near. But, though bishop Paul was more glad than any one else of these tidings, he carried himself so carefully in the matter that he would have the vote of all the chiefs and the wisest men before him in dealing with this matter; and there was not wanting a report among some men, that he did not want the

matter of the saintliness of the blessed bishop Thor-lac to get abroad. But he acted as he did, because he wished to give God the glory, that he had let that come about in his days the like of which had never happened, and because he wished the matter to be so carried that there might be most hope of God's approval. He thought it to be a matter of difficulty as it was, to set the matter going with a lofty balance, and that there might be found nothing blameworthy in its treatment, but no one believed earlier nor forwarded more than he did the glory and saintliness of the blessed bishop Thor-lac, though he walked more warily than other men [with regard to it]. Nevertheless it was the opinion of all the wisest men, according to the message of bishop Brand, that the relics of bishop Thor-lac should be translated this summer according as he had himself foretold in a manifest vision of Thor-ward the priest's the Yule next before this.

29

3. After the Moot the same summer that this was decided upon, bishop Paul sent word to bishop Brand, and to his brethren Sæ-mund and Orm, and to the sons of Gizor Hall's son, Thor-wald and Magnus, and to Thor-laf Thorlaksson of Hot-dale the mother's father of Herdis, to Cetil her son, to Thor-lac Cetil's son Herdis' brother, to priest Godmund Are's son, who was later bishop of Holar, and to many others of his dearest friends. For them that came bishop Paul prepared a costly feast, and afterwards there were taken up out of the earth the relics of the blessed bishop Thor-lac, and bestowed withal as worshipfully as beseemed it, according to the foresight and provision of bishop Paul, and straightway there followed mighty tokens, as it is told in his [Saint Thor-lac's] Life, and the glory was his, but the good-hap was bishop Paul's.

30

4. The next summer after [1199] the mass-day of bishop Thor-lac was made law throughout the whole land, and a two days' fast ordained withal. After this men sought thither out of all the country to do reverence to the blessed bishop Thor-lac with vigils and fasts, and

prayers and gifts, and thither too sought they that were travellers, many every season, both aliens and Icelanders, and paid their vows there that they had vowed, and gave into bishop Paul's hands, and told him every man the cause of his vow, and the token that they received in return, and this was ever glad tidings to him. They all carried away with them true proofs of the saintliness and glory of the blessed bishop Thor-lac and the hospitality and magnificence of bishop Paul.

31

5. But though the renown of bishop Paul was great as was deserved, before the saintship of bishop Thor-lac was mooted, it made his reputation still higher in that he had a mother's brother of true nobility, and many looked for the old saw to come true, that 'a man takes after his mother's brother.' And there were many tokens that it would be so, because he did in many things just as the blessed bishop Thor-lac had done. He was careful in his life and an observer of the offices, he mortified himself with fasts and with regard to raiment, he had moreover a touch of all those things which he could find out that the blessed bishop Thor-lac had in his behaviour, lowly and an almsgiver, living plainly and long-suffering, as in both [him and his foregoer] was proved by trials many and great during their bishoprics.

32

6. When bishop Paul thought that sufficient money had been gathered and brought together, of that which men gave out of their goodwill to the blessed bishop Thor-lac, then he quickly made manifest what he had made ready in his mind to do. He hired that goldsmith, whose name was Thor-stan, and who was the most skilful worker in metal of all Iceland. And so abundant were the bishop's supplies that there was no lack of anything that was needful for the work which he wished to have wrought.

33

He let a shrine be wrought, and furnished therefore abundantly moneys in gold and gem-stones and burnt silver. He laid out no less money upon the shrine and the hire of the smiths, with the

contributions of other men, than four hundred pieces of silver. This shrine was so beautifully wrought, that it no less excelled all other shrines that were in Iceland in beauty than it did in size, and it was more than three ells long, and there was no other longer than an ell of all those that were then in Iceland. No wise man who sees this shrine can question how magnificent a man he must have been who could have had this treasure made, or what wealth he must have had to have begun such a work.

34

7. 1. IN the days of bishop Paul there came out of Green-land bishop John, and he abode the winter through in East-frith, and then came to Seal-holt at the end of Lent to the bishop Paul; and he came thither on Shear-[Thurs]day [April 3, 1203], and both the bishops hallowed much anointing oil or crisma and they held many confidential talks and laid wise plans between them. Bishop Paul received him with the greatest honour, and gave him a worshipful feast while he was there, and led him on his way with great magnificence, both in gifts and other marks of honour. Bishop John taught men how to make wine out of crow-berries, accord- ing as king Swerre had told him. And it happened the next summer [1203] after there were berries almost everywhere in Iceland; and aman, whose name was Eiric, who dwelt a short way from Seal-holt at the homestead that is called Snorre's-stead, made some wine out therefrom, and it turned out well. But that very summer bishop John went to Norway and thence to Rome, and everywhere he came he spoke highly of the hospitality and dignity of bishop Paul.

35

2. In the days of bishop Paul, when Gizor Hall's son held the Law-speakership, there arose very much unrighteous dealing as to the ell, both among aliens and Icelanders, so that men thought it not to be borne any longer. Then bishop Paul gave this counsel in the matter, that men were to have for a measure sticks or yards two ells length. Then other chiefs lent their might with the bishop to the forwarding of this measure, Gizor and his sons, Thor-wald and Hall and Magnus, as

well as his brothers, Sæ-mund, who was then the most noble man in all Iceland, and Orm, who was both a good lawyer and skilled in most other knowledge, and all the chiefs, and it was then made law as it hath been maintained ever since.

36

3. In the seventh year of the bishopric of bishop Paul, Absalom, archbishop in Denmark, died on Bennet's-day [March 21, 1201], and in the same year bishop Brand died on Sextus-day [Aug. 6], and he had been bishop eight winters of the fourth ten [38], and was a great paragon. After the death of bishop Brand, the North-countrymen chose for bishop priest God-mund Are's son, and bishop Paul gave him his writ to arch-bishop Eiric, and God-mund was hallowed bishop in Thrond-ham ten nights before bishop John's-mass [April 13, 1203], and Hacon, son of king Swerre, was then king in Norway. Bishop God-mund came back to Iceland the same summer and came to East-frith, and then bishop Paul and he met, and they paid each other much honour in feasts and gifts. Then bishop God-mund went to Holar, and sat there in his see with the greatest discomforts on many accounts. His means soon became small, but the outgoings were hardly deemed moderate. And all that came in the way with him, held him rather stern and stiff in his commands. But bishop Paul waxed ever in love and friendship with the whole commonalty of the land, as men saw his prudence in everything, and his easiness in what he required and commanded to all that were in obedience to him; and all the people of the land would fain have had such a governor over them if they could have had their choice.

37

4. Bishop Paul had the number of the churches taken, that there was need of priests for, in the three Quarters of the country over which he was bishop, and he had the priests numbered, how many there were needed in his diocese. And there were two hundred and twenty churches, ten-told, and there were needed of priests ten less than three hundred, ten-told. And he had them numbered for this reason, that he

wished to give priests leave to go abroad if there were enough left behind in his diocese, and he wished also to provide, if need were, that there should be no lack of priests in his diocese as long as he was bishop.

38

5. In the twelfth year of the bishopric of bishop Paul there came to pass these tidings which were of great concern. There died Gizor Hall's son two nights before Olave's-mass [July 27, 1206]. Of him spake Sae-mund Paul's brother these words, that he was 'a rook or cornerstone of all merriment wherever he was present.'

39

6. Then also three nights before Ambrose-day the following winter [Dec. 4, 1206] there came up fire [was an eruption] in Hecla-fell for the third time.

40

8. 1. BISHOP Paul was such a fortunate man, that well-nigh everything went sun-wise [happily] with him in the earlier part of his life; and [this also he had] as may be heard in some degree in the [body or hull] of this story, I have told above, and there is nothing therein but what is true, that he became, as it were, the idol or teraph of all men. And Almighty God blessed him the more the longer he lived both in wealth and honour.

41

But if any one should think that, for love's sake, I have adorned the story of the life of bishop Paul more than there was any ground for, they do not guess right, for this rather sticks in my mind, that I have left out many notable things in the story of his life, by reason of lack of knowledge or by carelessness and laziness in writing, rather than that I have lied a whit in my story.

42

2. This happy plan moreover bishop Paul took up, when men suffered stress of bad seasons, and lacked crops and fish and most other winter provision, whereby there came about first a lack of food for beasts and

afterwards for men, — then he took this counsel, by the good-will of Thor-wald Gizzor's son and other wise men of his fellowship, to vow to God and the saints for bettering of the seasons, to sing three *Paternosters* every day to the glory of God and the memory of Saint Thor-lac the bishop, and on his day in the summer to give at the morning-meal the milk of his sheep and a bundle of hay from each cow's fodder, and a mark or half-pound out of each half-hundred weight [to the poor]; and there came never any famine more as long as he lived.

43

9. i. BUT inasmuch as God will not always try them whom He loveth with indulgence only, but will rather by temptation and trials make His servants perfect, if they stand fast, as there have been many ensamples: —

44

2. Now when bishop Paul was shining in such bloom that his worth and wealth were ever increasing, and Herdis was gathering in all kinds of things with her husbandry and prudence, which the estate stood in need of, with all the stewardship that was needful; for she was the most notable housewife in all those matters of business that there was a call for upon the estate at home or at any other of the homesteads that the bishop owned: their children became at once in their young years skilful: Loft in handicraft and learning and wisdom, Cetil in skill and handwriting, Halla in working and book-lore, Thora in obedience and love. Now inasmuch as God speaketh thus in the Gospel, that anything that is said shall be established by two or three witnesses [John viii. 17], I will set forth with one the testimony of A-mund the Smith, who was a man both of rule and truth. He made this verse —

45

God magnifies Loft with the highest gift, there is no stint therefrom, And the King of the Moon increases Cetii's estate by his power, And the Lord of all bestows a most blissful life on the Halla, And the dear Prince of the Archangels makes Thora thrive mightily.

46

[See Corpus Poet. Bor ii. 282.]

47

So it went with them ever in their life till the day that they were visited by misfortune.

48

10. 1. Now when bishop Paul had been at his see twelve winters [1207], it happened that Herdis went from home in the spring after Easter to Scard, to a homestead the bishop had there, and she was going to get servants and busy herself with other matters that were needful there. Two of her children, Cetil and Halla, went with her, but Loft and Thora were at home with the bishop.

49

But when Herdis was at Scard there came a great flood, and the river Steer-water or Theorso could not be ridden. But she wished to get home at the day she had named, because there was much at home unsettled, which it was meant should wait her coming. So she had a boat got and taken to the river, and they went down to the boat — Herdis, Cetil, and Halla, and John Herdis' brother, and a priest named Beorn chaplain of the bishop that served them, Sig-fus Grimsson the priest, a deacon of Scard named Thor-stan, Gud-run Thor-odd's daughter and Herdis' sister's daughter. Cetil and Beorn went across the river first, their horses and harness, and Herdis' riding horse was lost then. The last time, when they were to cross, there were on board the boat, Sig-fus Grimsson, Thor-stan the deacon, Herdis, and Halla and Gud-run, and the weather was somewhat squally. And when they got into the current, and were a short way from the shore they were about to go over to, they foundered, and the boat sunk under them, and they all went to the bottom, and all came up again, and both mother and daughter were heard to chaunt and commend themselves and their souls to God Almighty's hand. And there they that were to die, and they that were to live, parted: Sig-fus was driven ashore, but Herdis, Halla, and Gud-run were drowned, and Thor-stan the deacon; but Sig-

fus was much spent when he came ashore, but there was no man ashore that gave any help to them.

50

But Almighty God fulfilled all His promises, He that hath promised that He would 'give comfort with every grief,' and that 'He would try no one more [heavily] than he could bear' [by that which He lays upon him] [1 Cor x. 13]. And God showed this in both ways in the grievous mishap, for comfort came with grief, in that all the bodies of them that were drowned were found the same day, and this comfort was very great to them that survived, and yet it was little likely [that it could have happened], save God of His goodness and grace had granted it, for there was such a great flood, that a few nights later the horse that had drowned there was driven up on the West-men-isles.

51

2. But when these tidings came to the ear of bishop Paul suddenly at the dead of night, then it was manifest to all that God had measured close what he could bear. He could not taste any food, and could get no sleep before the bodies were buried, though he tried to cheer up as much as he could. But yet any one may tell what a trial he had, to have lost so grievously the persons he loved best, and to see sorrow continually in his children and in all those that he had to care for. He did all that had to be done for the dead with composure, both as regards fees to the clerks and also to the poor, for he perceived this, which is true enough, that in such matters 'a sinking plow [i.e.. deep plow] is better than a swaying one.'

52

3. The anniversary of Herdis and them that lost their lives with her is fourteen nights after the Invocation of the Cross in the spring [May 17,1207]. And it was many men's duty, both clerk and lay, to remember her [pray for her soul] as warmly and lovingly as their nearest kinswoman, because of her many housewifely charities [on their behalf].

53

4. Bishop Paul gave great comfort to Thor-lac Herdis' brother, both in words and in munificent gifts which he gave him, and held him with no less esteem than before he lost her; the bishop cared for Thor-lac no less than for his own children after her death.

54

Thora, bishop Paul's daughter, took the management of all indoors after the death of her mother, with the loving supervision of her father, though she was no older than fourteen years of age; and she carried all on so well that they that were best acquainted with her ways of management esteemed them the best.

55

The bishop so soon got the better of the grief that he had suffered, that many men thought there was little trace of it to be seen in him: and yet every one can clearly understand that it was more his long-suffering and his wish to appear cheerful to the people than because his sorrow ever went out of his heart as long as he lived.

56

11. 1. BISHOP Paul would seldom, in comparison with the former ways, save it were a high-day, preach a sermon, for he thought that they would care more for it if they could seldom get it; but he had two masses sung well-nigh every holiday, he himself preached a sermon four days every twelve-month, the first day of Yule, and the first Wednesday of the Fast [*Ash-Wednesday*], Shear-[*Thurs*]day, and the day of the [dedication of the] church, and only on any other day when he thought there was some need [to say somewhat].

57

And I put this down for this reason, that other most scrupulous and careful men have done likewise, and it is the greatest good for them that shall come afterward, that they may know as many ensamples as possible of such men's doings, for there is good to be got out of all.

58

At every place where he took quarters he himself made a discourse, or set another to do so, when he was holding his visitation in any part of

his diocese.

59

2. Several men were his chaplains; first the priest Thor-kel Hall's son, a good clerk and upright man, for some winters, until he entered the Order of Canons. After that priest Leg served him seven winters; and afterwards a North-countryman called Beorn, a man of small stature but wise and well-learned, and a foster-son of bishop Brand; afterwards he went abroad. After that priest Brand Dale's son served him, who had before served bishops Brand and God-mund. Priest Cetil Her-mund's son was also his servant [chaplain] before he died, and he took care of the choir of the cathedral and the clerks there after the loss of bishop Paul. The former bishops let the same chaplains serve them all through, each of them, that they might show the steadfastness and evenness of their temper in this as in much else. But why bishop Paul changed his chaplains was, because he thought it better that many should get rank and honour from him, and each man was in good esteem while he served him whatever might happen afterward.

60

12. 1. AT the time Herdis died, the case of the Northlanders between bishop God-mund and Colban Tumesson began to get troublesome, and as is well known, all the men in this country gat great distress through these troubles. But bishop Paul bore, the brunt of these troubles before any one else..., not before in the Northlanders Quarter. And he was in such troublesome position or sore stress in this matter, because the archbishop had sent him his letter with his seal that he should stay and strengthen, as far as his power would go, the side of bishop God-mund, while many dear friends of bishop Paul supported the side of Colban and kinsmen and relations of his own to whom he wished to show lovingkindness withal, yet he could do nothing. But it was no easy thing to make these matters right, inasmuch as bishop God-mund did not think himself upheld unless bishop Paul stood in the forefront with him, and he defied both men and the laws of the land, and interdicted and excommunicated every one that would do anything

against his will. But Paul was oftentimes a patient man, even though all was not done as he wished and as he saw it ought to be, and in this way he brought many to good fruit towards himself and God, and to others he gave gentle penances. Nevertheless they could not bear always to be in wrong; but bishop God-mund did not pay any more regard to those men that were in Paul's diocese, but interdicted them and excommunicated them as soon as they gave any judgment that was not to his mind, even though it were the lawful judgment. But bishop Paul would not let these sentences bite men [deep], but yet would lay upon them some small penance, for the safety sake of those that came under or were inmeshed in God- mund's cause, for Paul liked rather that those under his charge should undergo some [slight penance] rather than sit in terror as to whether the bishop's sentence might take effect in them or not.

61

2. But when the troubles ran so high that there was a battle wherein Colban and many other good men, both clerk and lay, fell [Sept. 9, 1208], and they that survived lost their [friends]. And after that the bishop and his men made an attack upon the survivors and the next-of-kin to Colban, and drove them away and took to themselves all that they had, and declared them to be under excommunication. But when bishop Paul knew and was aware of these tidings, he prayed his friends not to make an attack upon them at once, and his reason was that he knew [the old saw] that 'the blood-nights are the hottest,' and he hoped that this saw would be proved, and expected that matters would go more calmly and reasonably if they waited longer. And he hoped on the other side that bishop God-mund would see the flaw in his work and how much harm had come of it, and would make good offers of peace and honour to those that had the suits for the slain. But when this [hope] was disappointed, and there came news on the contrary of attacks against them, and robberies and assaults and well-nigh every kind of outrage, then Paul sent his chaplain Beorn to see bishop God-mund, and ask him to make amends and allay these troubles with...

offering to support him as thoroughly therein as was needed with good-will and his own means, in whatever way he could by money or other outlay, if he would only meet him half-way. It was manifest... the way bishop Paul had by his words hindered the chiefs from going north, first at harvest-tide while men's grief was the greatest and least abated the pain of the loss of men...; and then it was proposed to bishop God-mund that he should grant to his noble and good kinsmen some easy amends for what they had suffered than they had, for he wished to snatch God-mund and his followers out of instant jeopardy while yet it was possible. But bishop God-mund would not listen to it, and charged him with leaning towards the chiefs in making such proposals.

62

But it was soon made manifest which of the two had most wisdom and prudence in this, because in the same year the chiefs went to Holar [April 15, 1209], and drove bishop God-mund out of his see, and swept away that crowd of rascalry that was encamped there — outlaws and robbers and reavers, and slew some, and thereby that gang of malefactors was broken up, and thenceforward men had good luck [and peace].

63

Bishop Paul, with gentleness and good-will, asked bishop God-mund to come and stay with him, but he would not, and took great care not to meet him because he would not listen to his wholesome counsel.

64

13. 1. AT that time Loft, the son of bishop Paul, went abroad, and went to the homes of men of rank in their lands, to Bearne bishop of the Orkneys, and after to king Inge in Norway, and earl Hacon his brother, and from them he received worshipful gifts and much money. But as the bishop sat in much concern about his son and other news how things were going, God gladdened him so that one summer Loft came back with good renown and rich gifts that he had received, and he was

able to say that he had got a good welcome for his father's sake wherever he had been.

65

2. In that summer came thither [to Iceland] the treasures which Thore archbishop of Norway had sent to bishop Paul, a gold embroidered mitre, such as none as good had ever come to Iceland, a costly gold ring, and splendid gloves. But the next summer after, when bishop Paul had sat sixteen winters in the see of Seal-holt, there came out noble treasures which Nicholas, bishop of Oslo, sent to bishop Paul, a great finger-ring of gold that weighed two ounces, and a noble stone in it; and he sent him so much balm, that it looked as if there would never be any difficulty about the supply thereof any more, for there was nothing else so difficult to get among those things which it was necessary to have, and this could have cost no less than many marks of burnt silver.

66

3. It is also needful to put down, that bishop Paul also sent out many gifts to his friends, both hawks and other treasures. He sent archbishop Thore a bishop's staff, wrought out of tusk-ivory so skilfully that no man had ever seen one so well carven in Iceland as this which Margaret the Skilful had made, who was then the most skilful carver of all folk in Iceland. These two, both she and her husband Thore who was the steward, were both in Seal-holt when bishop Paul died, and she used to do whatever work the bishop set her to do. Bishop Paul had put in hand and had her begin a *tabula* [or *reredos*] for the altar before he died, and had meant to spend on it much money, both gold and silver, and Margaret carved it most nobly out of tusk-ivory, and this would have been the greatest jewel or masterpiece if, according to his plan, both Thorstan the shrine-maker and Margaret had wrought it out with their craft. But his death was a big black blow, and such things had to be put off for the sake of many other things that had to be done. Thorstan was appointed to make the *tabula*.

67

That same summer, when the bishop was last alive, there came out from Norway timber for a (*turret*) cap, which bishop Paul had had hewn, and at that time he paid for all the commodities that were needed for the bishopstead.

68

4. Now are told those things which fell out well this summer, but I will now put down those things which were held to be very much against the stream. There was that great earthquake the next day after the Selia-men's-mass [July 8, 1211], whereby many folks lost their life, and there fell down whole houses on many homesteads, and the greatest damage was done. There was also the greatest lack of dry weather, and much damage was done thereby [1211], The news of Clong Thor-wald's son's death were also brought out, who was held to bid most fair to be a great chief if his life lasted.

69

14. 1. THAT summer bishop Paul fell into sickness and disease, when he was going through the West-frith-men's Quarter, and with difficulty he reached Hot-dale. There he lay in bed well-nigh four weeks, afterwards he set out for home with little strength, coming home to Seal- holt three nights before Simon's-mass [Oct. 25], and at once went to bed. He sung the mass on All-hallow's-day [Nov. 1], and sung the last mass to the honour of God Almighty and all Saints for their help and mercy to him and all Christian men quick and dead. But before Martin's-mass he began to suffer with great pains from his illness, and there followed both sleeplessness and loss of appetite, and then it was thought to be a hopeless case. His sons and brethren and many more, of his friends were already there.

70

2. After this he sent to fetch Thor-wald and Magnus the sons of Gizor, and they came to Seal-holt, and to them he gave orders about everything according to his will. And he was anointed [received the unction] on the utas of Martin-mass. But before he was anointed with the holy unction, he made a long discourse after the example of Saint

Thor-lac the bishop. He confessed before all the clerks that were there harshly [toward himself] all the things that he thought he had done of bad ensample during his bishopric, and prayed all that they would forgive him that in which he had trespassed against them, and he cheerfully forgave all that in which any had trespassed against him, and commended himself to the mercy of God.

71

3. And after that he was anointed, [and] there was some relief in his v sickness, until he changed his chrisom clothes, and two nights afterwards, but then the disease of his sickness began to prevail upon or overwhelm him anew, and he lived no longer than two nights more, and then he received the body of the Lord at the point of death, and then fell asleep with God.

72

4. But a week before the death of bishop Paul the moon shone as it were the blood-of-sacrifice, and it gave no light at midnight in a clear sky, and this struck many men with great awe.

73

5. Paul was hallowed bishop in the days of pope Celestine by arch-bishop Absalom, in the days of king Sverre; he was then fifty years old. He governed God's Christendom [here in Iceland] with great temperance sixteen winters, and died the third day of the week one night before Andrew's-mass [Nov. 29, 1211], and there was then passed from the birth of God four years of the thirteenth hundred.

74

6. Priest Are the historian, who hath told together many memorable things, saith how heavily our land drooped after the loss of bishop Gizor, whom men esteemed the greatest man that had ever lived in Iceland [see Mantissa, ch. 1]. And here it may be seen how many fearful omens took place before the loss of this our precious chief, bishop Paul. — The earth shook and shivered for fear, the heavens and the clouds wept, so that great part of the growth of the earth was destroyed, and the heavenly bodies [stars] showed upon them the manifest tokens of

death when it was well- nigh come to the last hours of the life of bishop Paul; and the sea also burnt off the land, to which his bishopric reached. It did show as if all the elements showed upon themselves some mark of sorrow for his loss.

75

7. And the last night that bishop Paul was alive, Thor-wald Gizzor's son, the wisest of the chiefs, dreamed that John Loft's son commended to Peter the apostle the flock which his son, bishop Paul, had charge of; but [as] Jesus Christ commended His flock into the hands of His Father before His Passion, so bishop Paul commended himself and his flock to the care of Almighty God before he was called from us, who was our father and guide.

76

15. 1. AND now is here to be seen the whole bishopdom of the precious or goodly bishop from stem to stern; and we believe that we may not have spent the time thereon [unprofitably; for who of those to whom it was granted] to see the stern, would not be longing to see also the stem [the outset of his bishopric]?

77

Moreover this is a comfort for his loving friends that outlive him, that he hath left behind him well-nigh every legacy that can be taken after a goodly and worshipful man — *to wit*, worthy children, with good substance withal to recompense them that have suffered most by the death of bishop Paul; wealth enough and all kind of episcopal furniture, much finished, but some launched with good substance *or material for the * finishing thereof*, good counsel in his teaching, which he taught continually, both in words and by the fair example of his life; good promise and pleasant lodging, which he perfectly intended for the most of his nearest kinsmen. And he must have taken counsel to this end, that God would provide for them whom he had not made special provision for.

78

And this history of mine a wise man, Amund Arna's son, bishop Paul's smith, hath confirmed, and spoken these verses —

79

Sixteen years the speaker of God's law [canon law] ruled the bishop's see.

80

Now he is called hence to God: may Paul come into full peace! A maker of peace and lover of justice, he ruled his see righteously sixteen winters. His work won favour both with God and man.

81

Let us all intercede with God for him, That he may soon shine, the joyful bishop, in the choir of the patriarchs.

82

2. During the sixteen years when in God's Christendom [here in Iceland] was adorned with the blossom of the bishopric of bishop Paul, there were many great tidings in the world. There died pope Celestine, archbishop Absalom, king Swerre, Hacon [and] Guth-orm, kings of Norway; Cnut, Saurkwe, kings of the Swedes; Richard, king of the English: bishop Niai, bishop Brand, bishop John: Harold earl in the Orkneys, earl Philip: abbot Einar Mar's son, abbot Gud-mund Bialve's son: abbot Haflide Thor-wald's son, abbot Thor-kell Scum's son.

83

Many other noble men also died while Paul was bishop, both clerks and laymen — John Loft's son, Gizor Hall's son, Sig-mund Orm's son, Thor-laf Thor-lac's son, Thor-wald Thor-kel's son, Calf Snorre's son, Are Beorn's son, Aunund Thor-kel's son, Her-mund Cod-ran's son, Thord Snorre's son, Gud-mund A-mund's son, priest Berse Hall-dor's son.

84

Also there were many other great tidings in his bishopric, loss of ships and the eruption in Mount Hecla, war, rapine, and arson, and the death of men in many dreadful ways.

85

Epilogue.

86

3. Now I have gone through with haste the life of bishop Paul, but lack of skill rather than ill-will has prevented me from making 534 this History one of so great mark as the matter was fine which the bishop for his part furnished.

87

Almighty God gladden his soul in everlasting glory for ever. Amen.